

2026 Open Championship — Statistical Favorites

Royal Birkdale Golf Club | SeymourThomas.com

Methodology note: This model combines current-season form (Data Golf's skill rankings, OWGR, and 2026 season Strokes Gained: Total from PGA Tour/DP World Tour/LIV Golf) with actual Royal Birkdale course history from the last two Opens held there (2008 and 2017). Detailed Strokes Gained splits for those historical rounds are paywalled and weren't available, so the course-history factor is built from finishing position plus Data Golf's own course-profile insights (scoring variance, skill separation, and player-type fit).

Royal Birkdale: What the Course Actually Rewards

Pulled from Data Golf's Course Insights for the two most recent Opens held there:

	2008	2017
Scoring average	74.89 (+4.89)	71.28 (+1.28)
Score std. deviation	3.18 (high variance)	2.90 (typical PGA Tour variance)
Skill separation (slope vs. 1.0 = normal tour)	0.60	0.72
Player type favoured	Strongly favoured accurate drivers	Favoured accurate drivers

Two consistent signals across both years, 9 seasons apart:

1. **Royal Birkdale rewards accuracy off the tee over raw distance.** Both editions landed clearly in "favours accurate drivers" territory on Data Golf's Bomb-O-Meter — bombers get less of an edge here than at a typical stop.
2. **Skill separates less than usual (slope 0.60–0.72 vs. 1.0).** Meaning: the best players in the world beat the field by *less* here than they would elsewhere — variance, luck, and weather play an outsized role, and mid-pack players have a genuinely better chance than their ranking would suggest. 2008 (higher wind/weather year, scoring +4.89) showed this most starkly.

This doesn't override the skill/form model — it tempers it. A pure bomber with no Birkdale pedigree should be discounted slightly; a proven accurate ball-striker with course history should get a bump.

Adding Course History to the Model

Cross-referencing the 2008 and 2017 Open leaderboards against the current 156-player field turned up **10 players still competing who have real Royal Birkdale results on record**:

Player	Best Birkdale Finish	Years
Padraig Harrington	Winner , 2008	2008
Henrik Stenson	T3 (2008), T11 (2017)	2008, 2017
Alex Noren	T6 (2017), T19 (2008)	2008, 2017
Rory McIlroy	T4 (2017)	2017
Brooks Koepka	T6 (2017)	2017
Matthew Southgate	T6 (2017)	2017
Hideki Matsuyama	T14 (2017)	2017
Xander Schauffele	T20 (2017)	2017
Adam Scott	T16 (2008), T22 (2017)	2008, 2017
Rickie Fowler	T22 (2017)	2017

The Model

Data was loaded into SQLite across five tables: the 156-player Open field (with each player's Data Golf rank, OWGR, and tour rank), three Strokes Gained leaderboards (PGA Tour, DP World Tour, LIV Golf), and the Royal Birkdale course-history table above. Players were matched across tables by surname, with first-initial disambiguation for common names (Fitzpatrick, Kim, Hojgaard, Smith, Scott, Noren, etc.).

For each player, three factors were computed:

1. **Skill score** — derived from **dg_rank** (a predictive rank derived from [Data Golf](#), which already blends long-term skill with recent form)
2. **Form score** — current-season Strokes Gained: Total, normalized per round, pulled from whichever tour's leaderboard the player appears on

3. **Course-history score** — points awarded for Royal Birkdale finish (Win=10, top-3=8, top-6=6, top-15=2-4, top-25=1) summed across 2008 and 2017, normalized against the best score in the field

Because a hot stretch over just 18 rounds is far noisier than one over 60+, we applied **Bayesian shrinkage** to the SG figures, pulling small samples toward the field average before scoring, so a short hot streak can't outrank a full season of proven form.

The final composite: 70% skill rank + 30% shrunk current-season form, blended 88/12 with the Royal Birkdale course-history score. The 12% weight is deliberately modest, two tournaments is a small history sample, so it acts as a tiebreaker/booster rather than a dominant factor.

-- simplified core of the ranking query:

```
SELECT f.player_name, f.dg_rank, f.owgr_rank,

       COALESCE(p.total/p.rnds, d.total/d.rnds, l.total/l.rnds) AS sg_per_round

FROM field f

LEFT JOIN pga_stats p ON f.last_name = p.surname

LEFT JOIN dpwt_stats d ON f.last_name = d.surname

LEFT JOIN liv_stats l ON f.last_name = l.surname

ORDER BY composite_score DESC;
```

Top 15 Contenders (course-history adjusted, expanded stat coverage)

Rank	Player	DG Rank	Tour (SG/rd)	Birkdale History	Note
1	Rory McIlroy	2	PGA (+0.067)	T4, 2017	Elite skill + hottest full-season form + real Birkdale pedigree

Rank	Player	DG Rank	Tour (SG/rd)	Birkdale History	Note
2	Jon Rahm	5	LIV (+0.067)	none	Matches McIlroy's per-round form over a full 36-round season
3	Tyrrell Hatton	23	DPWT (+0.104)	none	⚠️ Only 18 rounds of data — highest raw SG/round, but small sample
4	Scottie Scheffler	1	PGA (+0.049)	none	#1 skill rank, but no Birkdale history and SG pace trails McIlroy/Rahm
5	Collin Morikawa	8	PGA (+0.043)	none	
6	Alex Fitzpatrick	28	PGA (+0.060)	none	Elite current form
7	Matt Fitzpatrick	3	PGA (+0.033)	none	
8	Tommy Fleetwood	4	PGA (+0.033)	none	Home-soil sentimental pick, no Birkdale Open history on record though
9	Cameron Young	9	PGA (+0.035)	none	
10	Xander	15	PGA (+0.029)	T20, 2017	Moves up on

Rank	Player	DG Rank	Tour (SG/rd)	Birkdale History	Note
	Schauffele				Birkdale pedigree
11	Sam Burns	6	PGA (+0.030)	none	
12	Russell Henley	11	PGA (+0.030)	none	
13	Ludvig Åberg	13	PGA (+0.029)	none	
14	Wyndham Clark	7	PGA (+0.026)	none	
15	Bryson DeChambeau	24	LIV (+0.039)	none	

Full ranking (all 156 players) and raw SQL tables are available in the linked files.

Three Most Likely Winners — and a Surprise Pick

1. Rory McIlroy. Tops every layer of the model: elite skill rank (#2), the hottest full-season Strokes Gained pace in the field (38 rounds, not a hot streak), *and* real Royal Birkdale pedigree (T4 in 2017). No one else in the 156-player field checks all three boxes.

2. Jon Rahm. Statistically even with McIlroy on SG/round, sustained across a full 36-round LIV season — this isn't a short-sample fluke. No recorded Birkdale history, so he's leaning entirely on current form and skill rank (#5), and it's enough to hold the #2 spot on its own.

3. Tyrrell Hatton. The highest raw SG/round figure in the entire field. The honest caveat stands — it's built on only 18 DP World Tour rounds, and Bayesian shrinkage pulled his score down accordingly — but even after that correction he's still #3. Worth taking seriously, not just as a value bet.

Surprise pick: Alex Noren. Ranked 21st overall — well outside the "favorite" tier — but he's the strongest Royal Birkdale course-history match of anyone in the field who isn't already a top-3 pick: T6 in 2017 and T19 in 2008, the only player besides Stenson and Scott with a real result in both editions. His current Data Golf rank (45th) and season form are solid-but-unspectacular, which is exactly why the model buries him — but "accurate, experienced ball-striker with two good finishes at a course that specifically rewards accuracy" is precisely the profile Royal Birkdale has rewarded twice now. Worth a longshot line on the site.

Note on Scheffler: The world's 1-ranked player sits 4th because he has no Royal Birkdale Open history in the data and his 2026 SG pace, while strong across 58 rounds, hasn't spiked the way McIlroy's or Rahm's has. Given the course's history of favouring accurate drivers and compressing skill separation, this is a course where even an all-time great gets less of an automatic edge than usual.